
Part of the **Enactus 101 Guide Series** — global guides designed to help every team learn, lead, and create impact.



PROJECT DEVELOPMENT & THE ENACTUS CRITERION

Everything about developing your project.

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LOCAL ACTION. GLOBAL IMPACT.



50,000 STUDENTS



1,050 UNIVERSITIES



2,690 PROJECTS



1,000,000+ LIVES IMPACTED

FROM 1 SEPTEMBER 2024 TILL 31 AUGUST 2025.

Every number reflects action. Every project, a purpose.

This is Enactus: a community of students, academics and business leaders using entrepreneurial action to tackle challenges, regenerate communities, and shape a more inclusive, thriving world.

Together, we are Generation Regeneration — changemakers with a head for business and a heart for the world.

As an Enactus student, you:

- work in teams to design and run real projects
- address social, economic, and environmental challenges
- learn by doing — with guidance from Faculty Advisors, alumni, and partners
- join a worldwide network of young leaders who want to make a meaningful difference

You are not just joining a club. You're joining a global movement of students in more than 30 countries who are building solutions that improve lives today and shape the future of work, business, and society.

OUR NETWORK OF ENACTUS COUNTRIES. #WEALLWIN



#GENERATIONRE | #ENACTUS | #WEALLWIN

About the Enactus 101 Series

This guide is part of the Enactus 101 Series — a set of simple, practical guides designed to help you learn, lead, build projects, measure your impact, and grow as a changemaker. We encourage you to explore the full series throughout the year.



WHAT THIS GUIDE IS / IS NOT

You've joined your Enactus team.
You've met your fellow students.
You've explored how the Enactus Impact Journey helps you grow as a changemaker.

Now it's time to learn how Enactus teams build strong, innovative, impactful projects.

This guide will show you:

- how to move from a challenge → to an idea → to a functioning social enterprise
- how to use the Enactus Judging Criterion as your compass
- how the Impact Journey guides every step of project development
- how to build your business model using the Enactus Social Business Canvas
- how every choice you make shapes your impact on people, planet, and prosperity

And to make everything practical and easy to follow, we'll use one example project throughout the guide.

Contents of this Guide:

- The Enactus Approach to Projects
- How Strong Enactus Projects "Think"
- Working Ethically with Communities
- Understanding the Enactus Criterion
- Theory of Change
- Introducing Your Project Development Tools
- The Enactus Impact Journey Roadmap
- The Enactus Social Business Canvas
- How to Use the Canvas
- Your Project Starts Now!



SPACE FOR NOTES:

THE ENACTUS APPROACH TO PROJECTS

WHAT TYPE OF PROJECTS SHOULD WE DEVELOP?

Enactus projects are built at the intersection of:

- Entrepreneurial leadership
- Innovation
- Strong business principles
- Meaningful social & environmental impact

Your team is not running charity programmes. You are building real social enterprises that:

- respond to a validated need
- create value for communities and customers
- can sustain themselves
- and (re)generate lasting change

Enactus is where students learn to design, test, and grow solutions that matter.

Throughout this guide, we'll follow one fictional Enactus project to show you how everything fits together:

EXAMPLE PROJECT: RETHREAD COLLECTIVE

A project that transforms textile waste into new products while collaborating with young women to build skills, income, and stronger futures – reducing waste and strengthening community resilience.

This example will help you visualise how project development works across the entire **Enactus Impact Journey**, across the **Enactus Social Business Model Canvas** blocks and how it aligns to the **Enactus Criterion**.



AND WE BELIEVE





Every impactful Enactus project starts with a way of thinking — not with a solution.



HOW STRONG ENACTUS PROJECTS “THINK”

Three mindsets guide you through the complexity of social challenges and help you design enterprises that support people and contribute to a healthier world:

- Human-centered design
- Systems thinking
- Entrepreneurial thinking

These mindsets help teams build solutions that are practical, ethical, and aligned with the long-term wellbeing of communities and the environment.

HUMAN-CENTERED DESIGN THINKING

Human-centered design starts by understanding people’s real experiences — their needs, challenges, and what matters in daily life.

How it helps

- Reveals true priorities
- Builds trust and co-creation
- Avoids assumptions
- Leads to solutions that fit real lives

Explain it simply: Design solutions that work for people because they’re shaped with people.

In practice

- empathy interviews
- shadowing and observation
- journey mapping
- co-creation workshops
- simple prototypes tested early

SYSTEMS THINKING

Problems like waste, inequality, or climate pressures exist within larger systems. Systems thinking helps you see those connections clearly.

How it helps

- Uncovers root causes
- Shows how factors interact
- Highlights leverage points
- Prevents “quick fixes”
- Helps you design for long-term change

Explain it simply: See the whole system so you know where your project can make the biggest difference.

In practice

- system maps
- stakeholder maps
- power mapping
- identifying incentives and bottlenecks
- finding leverage points

ENTREPRENEURIAL THINKING

Entrepreneurial thinking turns ideas into action. It helps you test quickly, learn fast, understand customers, and build models that can sustain impact.

How it helps

- Moves you from idea → prototype → solution
- Focuses on value creation
- Tests assumptions early
- Uses resources wisely
- Builds sustainable, adaptable models

Explain it simply: Entrepreneurial thinking helps you create something that works — and keeps working.



ReThread Example

Before scaling anything, the team tests a small batch of upcycled products with two retailers to understand demand, pricing, and design preferences.



ReThread Example

Women shared that they needed flexible work, not fixed schedules — shaping both the business model and the training approach.



ReThread Example

The team maps how textile waste, local manufacturing, gender norms, disposable consumer culture, and income inequality interact — and identifies upcycling as a leverage point with social and environmental benefits.

WORKING ETHICALLY WITH COMMUNITIES

Strong Enactus projects are built on partnership

Communities hold knowledge, experience, and insight that you cannot access from the outside — which is why collaboration is essential.

Working well with communities means recognizing strengths, being honest about power dynamics, and ensuring that decisions and benefits are shared.

What ethical collaboration looks like

- listening before proposing solutions
- respecting local expertise
- sharing decision-making
- acknowledging power differences
- ensuring the project supports dignity, choice, and agency
- avoiding dependency
- building relationships that last beyond a single activity

Explain it simply: *Strong projects are built with people, not for them.*



ReThread Example

The team collaborates with women's groups to select training content, choose product lines, set prices, and discuss how earnings should be reinvested.

ENACTUS TIPS

Tips for ethical community collaboration

✓ Start with listening

Spend time understanding community priorities before discussing solutions.

✓ Ask, don't assume

Check your interpretations, invite perspectives, and validate needs with the people affected.

✓ Share decisions early

Involve community members in shaping goals, timelines, and success measures.

✓ Make benefits mutual

Ensure the project adds clear value for the community — not just for the team.

✓ Be transparent about power

Acknowledge where influence sits and actively work to distribute decision-making.

✓ Focus on dignity and agency

Support choices, reinforce strengths, and avoid creating dependency.

✓ Build for the long term

Plan for continuity, handover, or community ownership beyond one activity or semester.



Innovation? You don't need a new technology — you need a better way of creating value.



UNDERSTANDING THE ENACTUS CRITERION

YOUR COMPASS FOR BUILDING STRONG PROJECTS

The Enactus Criterion is the compass for your project. It guides how you design, how you act, and how you understand the change you create.

Which Enactus team most effectively demonstrated entrepreneurial leadership to drive business and innovation for sustainable positive impact to benefit people, planet and prosperity within the last year?

Here's what each part means for your work:



ENTREPRENEURIAL LEADERSHIP

Students lead the process: researching, testing, adapting, and making strategic decisions.

What it looks like

- curiosity and initiative
- thoughtful risk-taking
- learning from mistakes
- clear decision-making
- building partnerships
- courage to adjust your direction when needed



USE OF BUSINESS PRINCIPLES

Your project becomes powerful when it stands on a solid business foundation.

This includes

- clear customer understanding
- real value propositions
- cost and revenue logic
- operational planning
- pathways to reinvest and grow

Business thinking makes your project sustainable — so your impact can grow over time.



INNOVATION

Innovation means creating new value — solving a challenge in a way that is more effective, more inclusive, or more sustainable.

Innovation can look like:

- new business models
- circular or restorative practices
- new uses for waste
- improved access for underserved groups
- redesigning an existing solution so it works better



SUSTAINABLE POSITIVE IMPACT

Impact is the change your project creates for people, the environment, and local prosperity.

Impact can be:

- improved livelihoods
- reduced waste or pollution
- increased wellbeing
- strengthened ecosystems
- new opportunities or skills
- long-term resilience

Explain it simply: *Impact is what changes because of your work — and lasts.*

SPACE FOR NOTES:

THEORY OF CHANGE

HOW YOUR PROJECT CREATES CHANGE — STEP BY STEP.

A Theory of Change helps you understand and explain how your project leads to meaningful outcomes.

It shows the clear pathway from what your team does → to what changes → to why those changes matter. **It keeps your project focused, grounded in evidence, and aligned with the Enactus Criterion.**

INPUTS | The resources you invest

Time, skills, resources, partnerships, community knowledge



ACTIVITIES / OUTPUTS | What your team actually does

People trained, products made, services delivered, materials collected, sessions led



OUTCOMES | The short- and medium-term changes (DIRECT & INDIRECT impact)

Improved skills, increased income, reduced waste, better access to resources, improved confidence or wellbeing, safer practices, stronger participation

Outcomes / Direct Impact are the changes or benefits that result from the project's activities.

In the Enactus context, we prioritize Direct Impact to ensure our projects create meaningful changes in the lives of people.



LONG-TERM IMPACT | The deeper, lasting difference your project contributes to

Stronger livelihoods, healthier environments, resilient communities, circular or regenerative value, long-term opportunity

Long-term impact describes the deeper difference your project contributes to over time — it is unlikely for Enactus teams to measure it directly within a competition year.



***IMPORTANT NOTE:** In the Enactus context, we prioritize direct impact to ensure your projects create meaningful changes. **Direct impact refers to the measurable benefits experienced by individuals you've directly worked with.** These benefits include new knowledge, skills, or resources they've gained and applied, directly because of your project within the current academic year.

INTRODUCING YOUR PROJECT DEVELOPMENT TOOLS

Every Enactus project grows through learning, testing, improving, and building — and two core tools guide you through this process: **The Enactus Impact Journey Roadmap & The Enactus Social Business Canvas.**

Together, they help your team move from understanding a challenge → to designing a solution → to building a sustainable model → to creating measurable impact.

These tools work side by side. The Roadmap shows the path your team follows. The Canvas helps you shape the project along that path. Use this page as your orientation before diving deeper.

THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

What it is:

A step-by-step process that guides your team through the development of a strong, ethical, entrepreneurial, and impactful project.

How it helps you:

- shows what happens in each phase (**JOIN** → **IDEA** → **ACTION** → **REFLECT** → **IMPACT**)
- explains when to research, design, test, measure, and refine
- keeps your team focused on learning before jumping to solutions
- aligns your work with the Enactus Judging Criterion

Explain it simply:

The Impact Roadmap is the journey your project follows from first insight to final impact.



THE ENACTUS SOCIAL BUSINESS CANVAS

What it is:

A visual map of your project that organizes your thinking into clear, connected blocks — from understanding the challenge to designing the solution, building the model, and measuring impact.

How it helps you:

- turns insights from the Roadmap into a clear project design
- shows the relationships between problem, solution, operations, finances, and impact
- grows with your project as you test and learn
- becomes your core tool for explaining your project to advisors, judges, and partners

Explain it simply:

The Canvas shows what your project is and how it works.



ENACTUS TIPS: USE THEM TOGETHER IN YOUR PROJECT DEVELOPMENT

As you move through each phase of the Impact Journey, different parts of the Canvas take shape.

- **IDEA** builds your understanding of the challenge
- **ACTION** develops and tests your solution
- **REFLECT** strengthens your model
- **IMPACT** captures what changed because of your work

By the end of your project cycle, the Roadmap tells the story — and the Canvas shows the structure behind it.

SPACE FOR NOTES:

THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

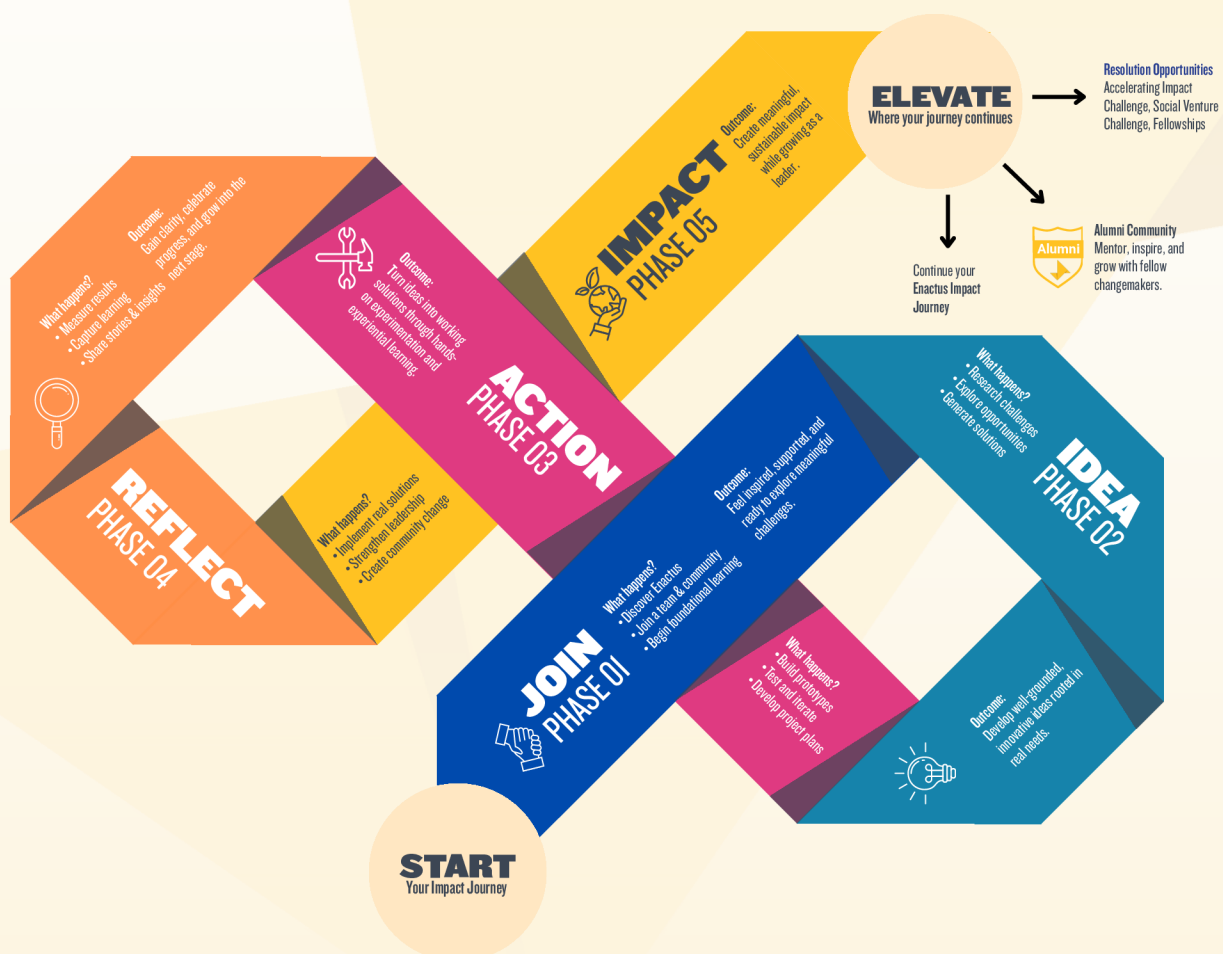
YOUR JOURNEY IS YOUR PROJECT PATHWAY

Every Enactus project follows the same journey. This roadmap helps you organize your work, make strong decisions, and understand what matters most in each phase.

The roadmap includes:

JOIN > IDEA > ACTION > REFLECT > IMPACT > (ELEVATE)

Each phase strengthens your project in a different way — and each connects to the Enactus Criterion and to the Enactus Social Business Canvas.





JOIN > IDEA > ACTION > REFLECT > IMPACT > (ELEVATE)

THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

JOIN | BUILD YOUR TEAM. BUILD YOUR SKILLS. BUILD READINESS.

JOIN focuses on students, not yet the project.

This is where your team develops the skills, values, and mindset needed to design ethical, entrepreneurial, and future-focused work.

What happens in JOIN:

- forming the team
- understanding Enactus' mission and culture
- learning the Enactus Roadmap & Criterion
- building familiarity with the Social Business Canvas
- training in human-centered design, systems thinking, and entrepreneurship
- establishing team roles, workflows, and values
- preparing for field engagement and ethical collaboration

Explain it simply: *JOIN builds the team before the solution.*

SPACE FOR NOTES:

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ReThread Example

Team members complete training in systems mapping, interviewing, prototyping, and ethical community engagement. They meet local women's organizations and textile factories to build trust and understand the landscape.

ENACTUS TIPS

Enactus Social Business Canvas alignment during JOIN:

- No Canvas blocks are completed yet
- BUT you build the skills and mindsets needed to complete them later

Questions to check readiness before IDEA:

- ☐ Do we fully understand the Enactus Criterion and how it connects to the Canvas?
- ☐ Are we trained in community engagement and ethical, human-centered research?
- ☐ Do we understand systems thinking and how it will inform Problem/System Insights?
- ☐ Are team roles and workflows in place so we can collect and analyze field data?
- ☐ Do we know how to explore problems without jumping into solutions?



JOIN > **IDEA** > ACTION > REFLECT > IMPACT > (ELEVATE)

THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

IDEA | UNDERSTAND THE PROBLEM, THE PEOPLE, AND THE SYSTEM.

IDEA is the foundation of your project. This stage is where you dive into the community, explore the issue, and identify opportunities.

Strong work in IDEA prevents weak solutions later.

IDEA requires:

- needs assessments
- interviews
- field observations
- system mapping
- stakeholder mapping
- understanding power dynamics
- identifying insights
- defining opportunity areas

This is where you shift from “we think we know” to “now we understand.”



ReThread Example

Through interviews, observations, and systems mapping, **the team discovers:**

- Factories produce large volumes of textile offcuts.
- Women have tailoring skills but lack workspace, childcare, and market access.
- Retailers want local, sustainable products but struggle to source them consistently.
- Waste collectors handle textile waste informally and unsafely.

Insights emerge:

- Waste is abundant and underused.
- Women want flexible, creative work that fits their lives.
- Retailers value sustainability and story-driven products.
- Small structural supports could unlock major opportunity.

Opportunity area identified:

A textile upcycling enterprise that builds income pathways for women while reducing waste.



Explore how the system could be healthier than before, not just less problematic.

ENACTUS TIPS

IDEA & Social Business Canvas Alignment

During **IDEA**, you complete the following Canvas sections:

☐ Mission (early draft); ☐ Problem Insights; ☐ Beneficiaries; ☐ Allies & Stakeholders; ☐ System Insights; ☐ Early Social Innovation Directions

Checklist before moving to ACTION:

- ☐ Have we validated the problem with people experiencing it?
- ☐ Do we understand root causes, not just symptoms?
- ☐ Do we know how the system creates and sustains the problem?
- ☐ Do we have clear insights that reveal unmet needs or leverage points?
- ☐ Have we identified opportunity areas that are ethical, feasible, and meaningful?



THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

1. UNDERSTAND THE PROBLEM

What this means

Look beyond the visible issue to find root causes, patterns, and deeper dynamics.

Examples

- Why does waste accumulate?
- Why are certain communities excluded from opportunities?
- What social or environmental pressures maintain the problem?

Explain it simply: *A problem is what causes what you see – not just what you see.*



2. UNDERSTAND THE PEOPLE

Use human-centered design to understand what people value and need.

Learn about

- lived experiences
- daily routines
- motivations
- needs and frustrations
- existing strengths
- what success means to them

Ask questions like

- “What would make the biggest difference in your life?”
- “What have you tried already?”
- “What gets in the way?”
- “How do you want to be involved?”



3. UNDERSTAND THE SYSTEM

Systems thinking helps you see the connections that shape the issue.

Map elements like

- cultural factors
- policies
- economic incentives
- environmental pressures
- supply chains
- existing organizations
- power relationships

Explain it simply: *Systems thinking shows where your project can create the biggest shift.*



4. INSIGHTS > OPPORTUNITY AREAS

Insights are “aha” moments that reveal patterns from everything you learned.

An insight is:

- a recurring problem
- a meaningful unmet need
- a hidden barrier
- a surprising motivation
- a leverage point

Opportunity areas come directly from insights.

Explain it simply: *Insights show what matters. Opportunities show where you can act.*



JOIN > IDEA > **ACTION** > REFLECT > IMPACT > (ELEVATE)

THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

ACTION | TURN INSIGHTS INTO A TESTABLE, FUNCTIONAL SOCIAL ENTERPRISE.

ACTION is where ideas turn into reality. This includes prototyping, piloting, building the business model, and operating your solution.

What happens in **ACTION**:

- Defining your value proposition
- Building your business model
- Early prototyping
- Piloting your model

Strong **ACTION** is not about doing a lot — it's about learning a lot.



ReThread Example

The team develops three prototypes:

- denim tote bags
- patchwork sleeves
- small accessories

They test them with two retailers and in a campus market.

They partner with a women's group for training, and a community center offers workspace access.

A six-week pilot reveals:

- high demand for two product lines
- need for simpler training modules
- pricing must adjust to better match production time
- reliable supply of textile offcuts requires formal agreements

The Canvas is updated with real data.

ENACTUS TIPS

ACTION & Social Business Canvas Alignment

During **ACTION**, you complete the following Canvas sections:

- ☐ Value Proposition
- ☐ Social Innovation
- ☐ Key Activities
- ☐ Cost Structure
- ☐ Revenue Streams
- ☐ Customers & Engagement
- ☐ Resources & Partnerships

Checklist before moving to **REFLECT**:

- ☐ Have we prototyped early and collected real user feedback?
- ☐ Does our value proposition resonate with both beneficiaries and customers?
- ☐ Did our pilot confirm or challenge our assumptions?
- ☐ Do we have real cost and revenue data (not guesses)?
- ☐ Have we captured evidence of what works and what doesn't?
- ☐ Have we updated the Canvas with real-world learning?



JOIN > IDEA > **ACTION** > REFLECT > IMPACT > (ELEVATE)

THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

1. DEFINE YOUR VALUE PROPOSITION

The value proposition explains why your solution matters and who benefits from it.

A strong value proposition answers:

- For whom?
- What problem?
- How does this help?
- Why is this better than alternatives?

Explain it simply: *Your value proposition is your promise of value.*



2. BUILD THE BUSINESS MODEL

The Social Business Canvas helps you design the structure that makes your solution work.

You'll define:

- Key Activities
- Key Resources
- Key Partners
- Customers & Beneficiaries
- Revenue Streams
- Cost Structure
- Customer Relationships
- Channels
- Reinvestment Logic

Explain it simply: *A business model describes how your idea creates and delivers value.*

And: simple is strong – clarity matters more than complexity.

3. PROTOTYPE EARLY

Prototypes help you test ideas quickly and cheaply.

You can prototype:

- product samples
- simple service walkthroughs
- training modules
- workflow diagrams
- digital mock-ups
- marketing messages
- pricing experiments

Explain it simply: *A prototype is a quick version of your idea used to learn fast.*

4. PILOT YOUR MODEL

A pilot is a small-scale version of your enterprise.

You learn:

- what actually works
- what beneficiaries need more or less of
- what customers want
- real operational costs
- real revenue possibilities
- partnership expectations
- risks and constraints

Pilots make your Canvas real.





THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

REFLECT | LEARN, ADAPT, IMPROVE.

REFLECT is where learning becomes strength.

Strong reflection helps you:

- improve your model
- refine your Canvas
- fix weak points
- highlight what works
- stay aligned with community needs
- prepare for greater impact

Reflection ensures you build a project that grows — rather than repeating the same mistakes.



ReThread Example

After piloting:

- Training is streamlined into shorter modules.
- Two product lines are selected for scaling.
- A new partnership with the community center ensures safe workspace access.
- A clearer agreement with the factory stabilizes waste supply.
- Participants report increased confidence and financial stability.

The project becomes more focused and more resilient.

QUESTIONS

People & Community

- Did the solution meet real needs?
- What feedback did we receive?
- Did participants feel included and valued?

Business

- Did revenue match expectations?
- Where did we overspend?
- What partnerships are essential?

Impact

- What changed?
- What surprised us?
- What needs deeper measurement next?

Team

- How well did we work together?
- What habits or structures need improvement?

ENACTUS TIPS

Reflect & Social Business Canvas Alignment

During **Reflect**, you complete the following Canvas sections:

- ☐ Value Proposition; ☐ Social Innovation; ☐ Key Activities; ☐ Cost Structure;
☐ Revenue Streams; ☐ Customers & Engagement; ☐ Resources & Partnerships

Checklist before moving to IMPACT:

- ☐ What did we learn from our pilot?
- ☐ Did we refine our solution in partnership with the community?
- ☐ Are our operations and partnerships stable enough to deliver consistent value?
- ☐ Do we have improved clarity on costs, revenue, and resource needs?
- ☐ Is our updated Canvas a realistic blueprint of how the project works?



Reflection is continuous — not one stage done once.



JOIN > IDEA > ACTION > REFLECT > **IMPACT** > (ELEVATE)

THE ENACTUS IMPACT JOURNEY ROADMAP

IMPACT | DEMONSTRATE REAL CHANGE — SUPPORTED BY EVIDENCE.

Impact is the heart of the Enactus Criterion.

Impact isn't what you did — it's what changed because of what you did.

Impact includes change in

- people's lives
- environmental health
- community resilience
- economic opportunity
- skills, wellbeing, and autonomy
- long-term systems

Impact becomes powerful when it is:

- measured
- meaningful
- credible
- connected to community priorities



ReThread Example People

- 15 women trained and change measured; 10 earning regular income
- increased confidence, financial autonomy, and skills

Planet

- 220 kg of textile waste reused or repurposed
- reduced environmental pressure

Prosperity

- retailers source sustainable goods
- revenue reinvested into new training cohorts

Impact shows the project works — and can grow.



Impact measurement and reporting are covered in depth in Guide 4.

ENACTUS TIPS

IMPACT & Social Business Canvas Alignment

IMPACT completes your Canvas:

☐ Impact (People, Planet, Prosperity)

Checklist to finalize the Impact section of the Canvas and prepare for competitions:

- ☐ What has changed because of our work (not just what we did)?
- ☐ Have we measured outcomes for people, planet, and prosperity?
- ☐ What impact was direct? What was indirect? What was not impact, but reach?
- ☐ Do we have credible evidence to support our impact claims?
- ☐ What does our continuity or scaling plan look like?

THE ENACTUS SOCIAL BUSINESS CANVAS

INTRODUCING THE ENACTUS SOCIAL BUSINESS CANVAS

A clear way to design, test, and strengthen your Enactus project.

Every Enactus project begins with an idea — but strong, sustainable impact requires more than inspiration. It requires understanding the problem deeply, designing the right solution, building a workable model, and measuring the change you create for people, planet, and prosperity.

The Enactus Social Business Canvas is the tool that guides you through this journey. It helps you shape your project step by step as you move through **The Enactus Impact Journey** — **JOIN** → **IDEA** → **ACTION** → **REFLECT** → **IMPACT**.

The Canvas keeps your thinking focused, your ideas structured, and your work aligned with the **Enactus Judging Criterion**. It ensures your project is:

- rooted in real community needs
- designed with systems awareness and ethical engagement
- tested and developed through entrepreneurial thinking
- financially and operationally sound
- accountable for the impact it creates

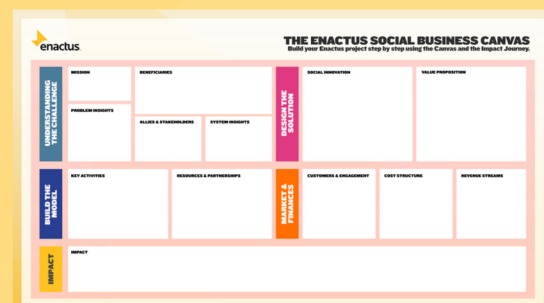
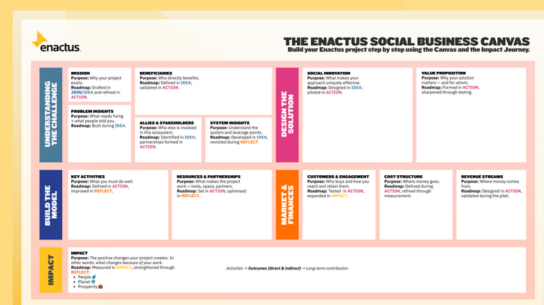
This Canvas is not meant to be completed in one sitting. You will build it layer by layer as your understanding and your project grow.

WHAT THE CANVAS IS

The Enactus Social Business Canvas is a visual map of your project. It helps you organize everything you are learning, deciding, and creating into one clear structure.

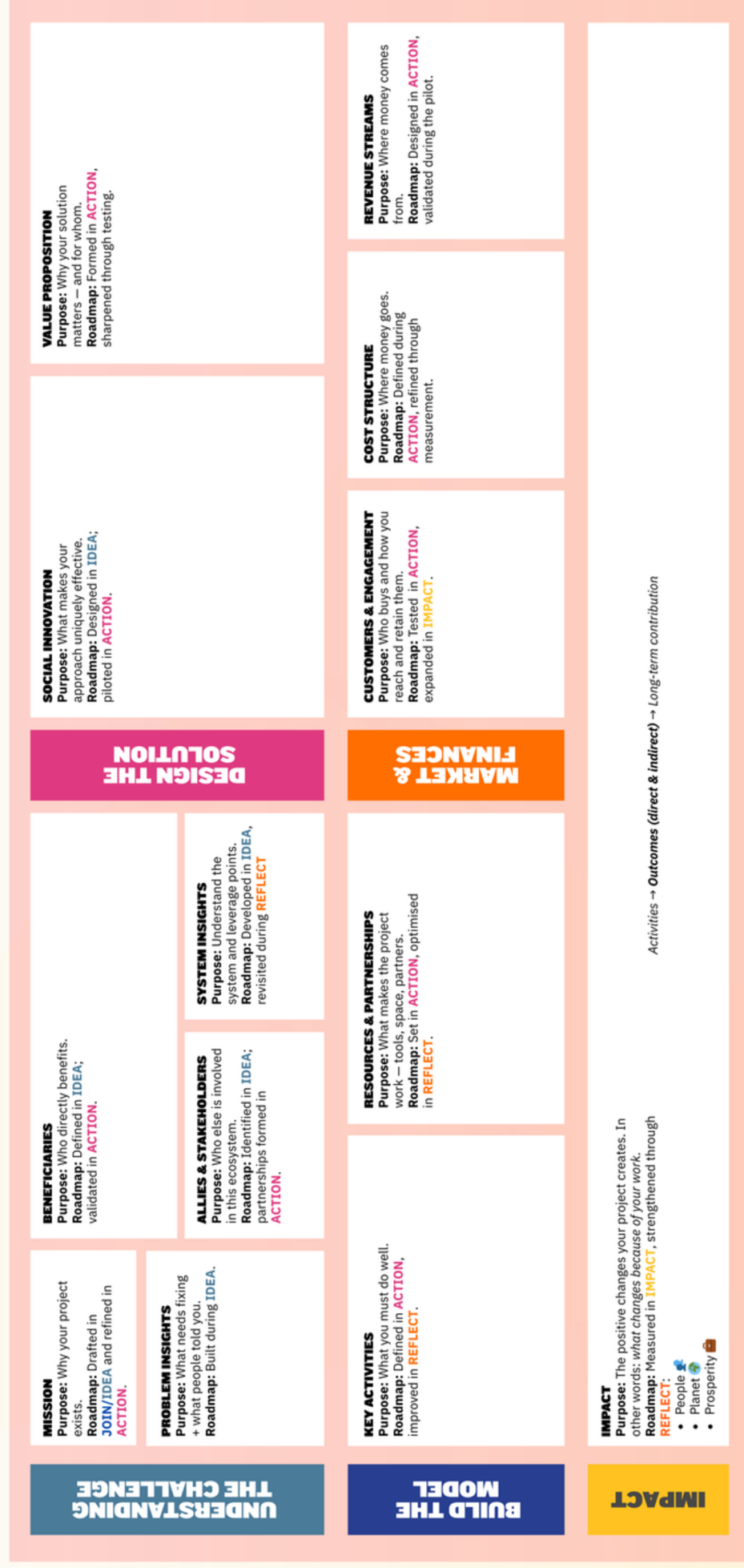
It brings together three essential domains of social entrepreneurship:

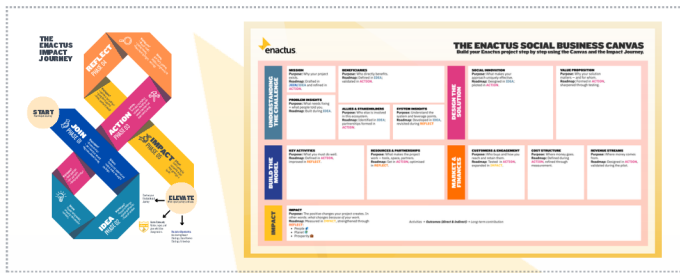
1. **Understanding the Challenge:** Who is affected, what the real needs are, how the system works, and where your project can create meaningful change.
2. **Designing and Building the Solution:** What makes your approach innovative, what value you create, and how your project functions operationally.
3. **Market, Finance, and Impact:** Who buys or supports your work, how your project sustains itself, and what impact it creates over time.



THE ENACTUS SOCIAL BUSINESS CANVAS

Build your Enactus project step by step using the Canvas and the Impact Journey.





The Enactus Impact Journey and the Enactus Social Business Canvas work together. Use both to build projects that create real, lasting impact.



HOW TO USE THE CANVAS

You will return to the Canvas many times throughout the year. Think of it as a living document — a model that grows as your project grows.

JOIN > IDEA > ACTION > REFLECT > IMPACT > (ELEVATE)

During JOIN

You begin building the foundations:

- learning the Enactus Roadmap and Criterion
- beginning to understand your mission
- developing your research, design, and entrepreneurial skills

No boxes are completed yet — but this is where your readiness to use the Canvas is built.

During IDEA

You explore the challenge in depth. You fill in the blocks related to understanding the landscape:

- Mission
- Problem Insights
- Beneficiaries
- Allies & Stakeholders
- System Insights
- Early thinking on Social Innovation

This phase is about listening, researching, mapping, and learning before deciding.

During ACTION

You start building and testing your solution. Most of the Canvas develops here:

- Social Innovation (prototype → pilot)
- Value Proposition
- Key Activities
- Resources & Partnerships
- Customers & Engagement
- Cost Structure
- Revenue Streams

Your Canvas becomes the blueprint of your social enterprise.

During REFLECT

You adjust your model based on what you learned in testing and piloting:

- refine your understanding of the problem
- strengthen your activities and partnerships
- update costs and revenue
- adapt your solution based on evidence

This is where iteration and improvement happen.

During IMPACT

You complete and use the Canvas to:

- measure your outcomes
- capture the positive changes you created
- demonstrate impact on people, planet, and prosperity
- communicate your project clearly to judges, partners, and communities

The Canvas becomes your story of how change happened.

The Enactus Social Business Canvas is more than a planning tool — it is the living blueprint of your project. You will return to it continuously as you learn, test, adapt, and grow.

*Each phase of the **Enactus Impact Journey** strengthens a different part of the Canvas, helping you move from understanding the challenge → to designing a solution → to building a sustainable model → to demonstrating meaningful impact.*

In the following pages, each Canvas block is explained with prompts, simple definitions, and examples to help your team translate insights into a clear, entrepreneurial, community-centered social enterprise.

ENACTUS SBC: BLOCK-BY-BLOCK

UNDERSTANDING THE CHALLENGE

MISSION

Purpose: Describe why your project exists and the change you aim to create.

Explain it simply: Your mission says why your project matters.

Prompts:

- What positive change are we working toward?
- Who do we support, and why?
- How will the world be better because of our work?



ReThread Example:

"To reduce textile waste and create flexible income opportunities with young women by transforming discarded fabrics into useful, high-quality products."

PROBLEM INSIGHTS

Purpose: Explain the social and environmental problem and what you learned from people experiencing it.

Explain it simply: What needs fixing — and how people experience it.

Prompts:

- What problem exists here?
- What are the root causes?
- How does this problem affect people day to day?
- What did people tell us about their challenges?



ReThread Example:

Factory waste is discarded weekly. Young women seek flexible work but face barriers to stable and safe income. Retailers want sustainable products but lack reliable local suppliers.

BENEFICIARIES

Purpose: Identify who directly benefits from your project.

Explain it simply: Beneficiaries = whose life improves.

Prompts:

- Who gains new opportunities from our project?
- Who gains skills, income, or access?
- Who experiences meaningful change because of this work?



ReThread Example:

Young women (18–30) seeking flexible income, skills training, and safe working opportunities.

SYSTEM INSIGHTS

Purpose: Understand how the issue fits into the wider system, and where your project can create leverage.

Explain it simply: See the bigger picture — and where your project can shift it.

Prompts:

- What fuels this problem?
- What policies, cultural dynamics, or incentives matter?
- What environmental factors play a role?
- Where are the leverage points for positive change?



ReThread Example:

*Waste → landfill pressure → environmental harm
Gender norms → few flexible work options for young women
Retailers → growing demand for sustainable, local products
Leverage point: transforming waste into value while creating new income pathways.*

ALLIES & STAKEHOLDERS

Purpose: Map the people and organizations connected to the issue — and who may become partners.

Explain it simply: Who else is involved? Who influences the system?

Prompts:

- Who already works in this space?
- Who controls resources or decisions?
- Who has community trust or key knowledge?
- Who could we collaborate with?



ReThread Example:

Women's cooperatives, textile factories, community centers, and retailers seeking sustainable goods.

ENACTUS SBC: BLOCK-BY-BLOCK

DESIGNING THE SOLUTION

SOCIAL INNOVATION

Purpose: Describe what makes your solution new, different, or more effective.

Explain it simply: Innovation = what makes your approach better.

Prompts:

- What's the creative leap?
- What new value are we creating?
- How does this support both people and the environment?
- What makes this different from existing solutions?



ReThread Example:

Micro-upcycling studios inside community centers that turn fabric waste into new products, while creating local income for young women.

VALUE PROPOSITION

Purpose: Explain the value your solution provides to beneficiaries, customers, and partners.

Explain it simply: Your value proposition is your promise.

Prompts:

- Who is this for?
- What needs are we meeting?
- Why will they care?
- What makes our approach valuable?



ReThread Example:

"For young women seeking flexible income, ReThread offers skill-building and workspace to earn through sustainable product creation. For retailers, we provide consistent, high-quality circular products with a compelling social impact story."

BUILDING THE MODEL

KEY ACTIVITIES

Purpose: Identify the essential actions needed to deliver your solution.

Explain it simply: Identify the essential actions needed to deliver your solution.

Prompts:

- What activities create value?
- What must happen daily, weekly, or monthly?
- What processes are core to delivering the solution?



ReThread Example:

Collecting textile waste, training participants, producing goods, managing partnerships, distributing products.

RESOURCES & PARTNERSHIPS

Purpose: Identify the tools, spaces, materials, skills, and partnerships needed to make the project work.

Explain it simply: What the project depends on.

Prompts:

- What tools or equipment do we need?
- What skills or expertise are essential?
- What space, materials, or technology are required?
- Who are our key partners and why?



ReThread Example:

Sewing machines, training materials, workspace, fabric offcuts, skilled volunteers, partnerships with women's cooperatives and factories.

ENACTUS SBC: BLOCK-BY-BLOCK

MARKET & FINANCES

CUSTOMERS & ENGAGEMENT

Purpose: Identify who buys or supports your work — and how you build strong relationships with them.

Explain it simply: Who pays, and how we connect with them.

Prompts:

- Who are our customers?
- How do they hear from us?
- What keeps them engaged?
- What service or communication do they expect?

ReThread Example:

Local boutiques, sustainable retailers, online shoppers. Engagement through quality, consistency, impact storytelling, and reliable delivery.

COST STRUCTURE

Purpose: Outline the major costs of running the project.

Explain it simply: Where the money goes.

Prompts:

- What are our fixed costs?
- What are our variable costs?
- What costs will grow as we scale?

ReThread Example:

Training materials, workspace utilities, transportation, equipment maintenance, packaging.

REVENUE STREAMS

Purpose: Explain how the project generates income

Explain it simply: Where the money comes from.

Prompts:

- What do we sell?
- Who pays for what?
- Are there multiple sources of revenue?

ReThread Example:

Retail orders, direct-to-consumer sales, custom product batches.

IMPACT

IMPACT (People, Planet, Prosperity)

Purpose: Describe the positive changes your project creates — measured through outcomes and longer-term contribution.

Explain it simply: What changes because of your work.

Prompts:

- How do people's lives improve?
- How is the environment better?
- How does local prosperity grow?
- What outcomes are direct? Which are indirect?

ReThread Example:

People: increased income, skills, confidence; **Planet:** textile waste reduced and reused; **Prosperity:** new markets for sustainable local goods

SPACE FOR NOTES:



YOUR PROJECT STARTS NOW!

Bringing It All Together

Every Enactus project begins with a question:

How can we create meaningful, sustainable change with entrepreneurial action?

This guide has given you the tools to answer that question:

- The **Enactus Criterion** to guide your decisions
- The **mindsets** that shape strong social innovation
- The **Impact Journey** to walk you through each phase
- The **Enactus Social Business Canvas** to turn learning into a clear, functioning model
- **Practical examples** to show how insights become impact

But the most important part is what comes next: your team, your partners, your community — and your commitment to building something that matters.

Great projects don't appear fully formed. They grow through curiosity, empathy, experimentation, reflection, and courage.

Your next steps:

1. Start with people — listen deeply.
2. Understand the system — see the whole picture.
3. Prototype early — learn fast.
4. Build your Canvas — make your model real.
5. Measure what changes — and use it to grow.

You are Generation Regeneration.



About the Enactus 101 Series

This guide is part of the Enactus 101 Series — a set of simple, practical guides designed to help you learn, lead, build projects, measure your impact, and grow as a changemaker. We encourage you to explore the full series throughout the year.



THE ENACTUS 101 GUIDE SERIES (OVERVIEW PAGE)

Guide 1 — Welcome to Enactus & Your Impact Journey

The core starter guide for all students.

Guide 2 — Building an Enactus Team (Team Structure, Culture & Leadership)

Covers team roles, leadership development, recruitment, culture, conflict resolution.

Guide 3 — Project Development & the Enactus Criterion

Research, Human-Centered Design- and Systems Thinking, the Enactus Criterion, The Enactus Impact Journey Roadmap, Enactus Social Business Canvas, ethical guidelines.

Guide 4 — Measuring Impact (Data, Storytelling & Reporting)

Impact metrics, surveys, dashboards, how to use Impact & Financial Review tools.

Guide 5 — Preparing for Competitions (Nationals & World Cup)

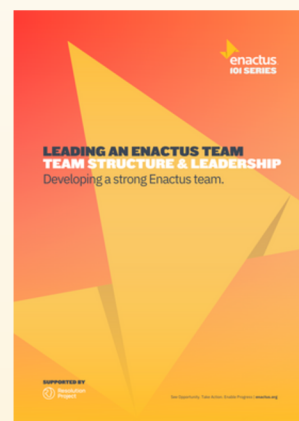
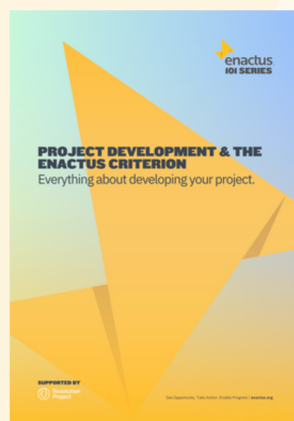
Storytelling, presentation logic, project evidence, competition philosophy, Gen:Re identity.

Guide 6 — Working with Partners & Advisors

Faculty Advisors, Business Advisory Clusters, institutional support, partner engagement.

Guide 7 — Faculty Advisor Guide

A practical guide supporting faculty to mentor, empower, and champion Enactus students.



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